ACME systems after such a change, his employment credential would no longer meet policy requirements, even if it remained cryptographically valid.

These trust-store entries become part of ACME’s governance layer and are distributed using ACME’s policy information points (PIPs) that we discussed in chapter 12. PIPs expose trust decisions as structured signals that PEPs and PDPs can rely on during request assembly and policy evaluation. This allows the authorization system to depend on verifiable credentials without embedding issuer lists into policies or spreading trust decisions across multiple systems. The trust store consolidates ACME's determinations about which claims from specific issuers should be accepted and for what purposes.

16.4 Credential freshness, revocation, and assurance

Trusting an issuer is only the first step. ACME must also verify that the credentials it assesses reflect the current state of the world. As discussed in chapter 12, authorization depends not only on the accuracy of each signal but also on its freshness and assurance level. These principles directly apply to verifiable credentials. A credential can be cryptographically valid and still no longer represent an accurate fact if the holder’s employment has ended, the issuer has lost its accreditation, or the credential has been revoked. Therefore, ACME must include mechanisms to validate the current status of credentials each time they are presented.

Most verifiable credentials include an expiration date that limits how long they remain valid. This provides a basic level of freshness. AuditsRUs might issue Angela an employment credential valid for a fixed term, such as one year, which must then be reissued using normal HR procedures. Similarly, NISA might issue a CISA-R certification credential with a renewal cycle defined in its governance framework. While expiration dates set predictable limits on each credential's use, they don’t cover cases where a credential becomes invalid unexpectedly, such as when someone leaves a company or loses their certification. For such situations, ACME depends on revocation information published by the issuer or its governance authority.